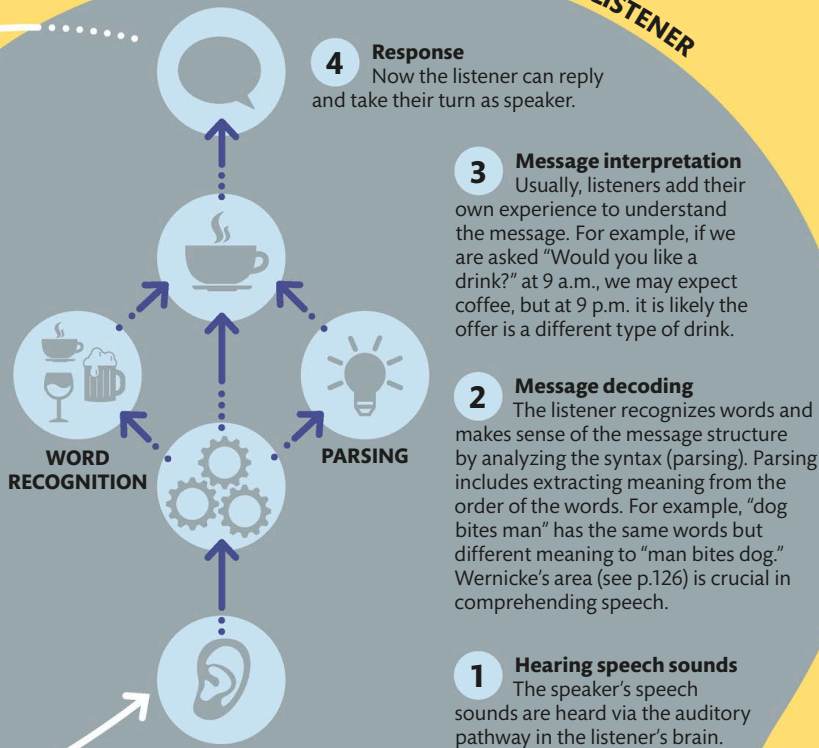




Having a Conversation

A conversation is a shared endeavor between speaker and listener, which involves more than producing and understanding words. We take turns, signal understanding, and align our thoughts.

THE LISTENER



Speaking and listening

Speaker and listener swap roles many times in a conversation—and as speakers, we also monitor our own speech output. Although both roles involve multiple steps, it can all happen fast—taking from 0.25 seconds between having an idea to saying it, and from 0.5 seconds for comprehension. Hesitation occurs when speakers need time to "catch up" with the complex speech planning and production process.

Beyond words

We constantly use nonverbal signals alongside speech in conversation. In addition to adding emphasis (via facial expressions) or visual effect (via gestures), such signals allow the person not speaking to have a role in the conversation partnership, encouraging the speaker without interrupting or taking over.

ELEMENTS OF CONVERSATION



Looking

Listeners look at their conversation partner much more than speakers do. They do this to show interest—as without this, speakers often falter. In contrast, speakers look intermittently at the listener.



Gestures

We use many types of hand gestures (see p.119), including conventional signs—such as "thumbs up," pointing, and expressive hand movements—to add emphasis to the message.



"I'm listening" signals

Listeners use nonverbal sounds and gestures, such as saying "mmm" or nodding, to show they are engaged in the conversation while not speaking.



Turn taking

Conversation requires taking turns, and we start learning this from infancy. Conversation partners rarely talk over each other, even though the average gap between turns is only a few tenths of a second.

PEOPLE TALK
OVER EACH
OTHER LESS
THAN 5% OF
CONSERVATION TIME

